Required Affinity Home Group Exercises for BIPOC Participants

Format and Process

Brief check-in, 5-minute meditation at beginning of each session; brief checkout at the end.

Please rotate the facilitation role among the group members, with a different person facilitating each meeting. The facilitator will keep time, ring the bell at the beginning and end of the meditation, and guide the group to follow the agenda. The meeting timeline should be held flexibly; if the group needs more time for a particular item, the time frames can be adjusted by agreement of the group.

Each group member is encouraged to help monitor the process by speaking up skillfully if the group is drifting off point and/or by offering gentle reminders of the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions***.

One of the best ways to ensure real inclusivity is by practicing mindful listening, avoiding cross-talk, and methodically going around the circle in response to a question or discussion topic. This practice systematically invites all voices. Anyone who feels like speaking first starts the circle for a question or activity. This way, the same person isn't starting every time. When the first person is finished sharing, they call on the next person, and so forth, until everyone has spoken. **It's OK to pass** on any given round. Use the **Right to Pass** agreement sparingly and take time to reflect if you are passing more than once in a meeting.

Session 1

00 Introductions: Share your name, pronouns, geographic location, and a “fun fact” about yourself (you can use the prompt “If you really knew me, you would know …”).

10 Silent mindfulness meditation on breath, body, or sound

15 Read the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions*** aloud as a group. Go around the circle with each person reading one. Go around again with each person sharing:

- One agreement that comes easily for you
- One agreement that is challenging, that you want to work on

25 **Discussion.** Go around the circle with each person sharing; please divide the time equally among participants, and wait until everyone has shared before sharing again.

- What was one of the first times you remember being aware of race—your own or someone else’s? Briefly describe the context, the content, and the emotions/thoughts you had.

- What is the relationship between skin color and caste, or class, where you live? In general, what is the race or skin color of the people with the most resources and access to resources? With the least access to resources?
- How has this relationship—relationship between skin color and caste, or class—impacted you and your life? Or has it not?
- Do you identify as a person of color, a BIPOC person? Why or why not?

45 Reflections on today’s conversation. Go around the circle with each person sharing what stood out for you in today’s sharing/listening. Please divide the time equally among participants. Stay rooted in the agreements of **Practice Self-Focus** and **Try It On**.

55 One-sentence checkout. Go around the circle with each person offering one or two sentences about how the conversation today was for them.

Session 2

00 Check-ins: Two or three sentences about the energy you are bringing to the group today, and one thing that stays with you from the Session 2 video.

10 Silent mindfulness meditation on breath, body, or sound

15 Review the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions*** by going around the circle with each person reading one agreement.

25 **Discussion.** Go around the circle with each person sharing; please divide the time equally among participants, and wait until everyone has shared before sharing again.

- Share from your journaling exercise: Where did you identify the Four Levels of Oppression in the context of your own life, or in your experience of the world around you?
- Has oppression shown up in your relationship with yourself or other people? If so, how?
- Share the list you made of your identities with your Home Group. What was your experience writing this list? Of sharing it now?

55 One-sentence checkout. Go around the circle with each person offering one or two sentences about how the conversation today was for you. Stay rooted in the agreement of **Practice Self-Focus**.

Session 3

00 Check-ins: Two or three sentences about the energy you are bringing to the group today, and one thing that stays with you from the Session 3 video.

10 Silent metta meditation

15 Review the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions*** by going around the circle with each person reading one agreement.

20 **Sharing.** Take turns sharing your experience of creating the Power Flower diagram, and of observing which identities you listed after the last session. Stay rooted in the agreement of **Practice Mindful Listening** without offering advice or commenting on others' experiences.

- Which characteristic or characteristics do you most identify with?
- Which ones do you leave out or just not think about often?
- How does this relate to the way in which society as a whole might privilege or marginalize parts of your identity/lived experience?

30 **Discussion.** Go around the circle with each person sharing; please divide the time equally among participants, and wait until everyone has shared before sharing again.

- How have you experienced the power dynamics that exist within POC communities, based on identities and characteristics other than race?
- How might one's racial characteristics impact how society relates to their other identities, such as gender, age, sexual orientation, or ability?
- What does all this mean for you as a mindfulness teacher? What does it mean for your students and what they might be showing up with, consciously or unconsciously?

50 Checkout: Each person shares what stood out for them in this conversation.

Session 4

00 Check-ins: Two or three sentences about the energy you are bringing to the group today, and one thing that stays with you from the Session 4 video.

10 Silent meditation using Pause-Relax-Open:

- **Pause:** When you notice your mind has wandered, you call your awareness into the present moment with “pause.”
- **Relax:** Invite your body to relax. Belly soft, breath deepens. Bring kind acceptance to whatever sensations, thoughts, or feelings are present.
- **Open:** Expand your attention outward, extending your awareness beyond your body and mind.

20 **Discussion.** Take turns sharing your experience of journaling on the prompts about microaggression. Stay rooted in the agreement of **Practice Mindful Listening** without offering advice or commenting on others’ experiences.

- As you reflected on your own life, were you able to bring to mind a time a microaggression has happened to you, and to write down what happened and how you responded at the time? What was your experience of doing this?
- Has there ever been a time when you harmed someone else with your language or assumptions about them?
- What, if anything, might you do differently now, either on your own or with the other person?
- How do you resource yourself when you experience microaggression or another kind of implicit bias? What about when you realize you’ve harmed someone else in this way?

55 One-sentence checkout. Go around the circle with each person offering one or two sentences about how the conversation today was for them.

Session 5

00 Check-ins: Two or three sentences about the energy you are bringing to the group today, and one thing that stays with you from the Session 5 video.

10 Silent Pause-Relax-Open meditation

15 Review the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions*** by going around the circle with everyone taking turns reading an agreement.

20 **Discussion.** Go around the circle with each person sharing; please divide the time equally among participants, and wait until everyone has shared before sharing again.

- What stood out for you in the conversation that unfolded between the teachers on the panel? And why did it stand out?
- Did any of the panelists share experiences that you relate to? If so, what were they?
- What, if any, strategies or perspectives that the panelists shared will you use for support as you move forward on the teacher path?

55 One-sentence checkout. Go around the circle with each person offering one or two sentences about how the conversation today was for them.

Session 6

Required Affinity Home Group Assignment

- Before the Required Affinity Home Group meeting, please complete this written assignment (maximum 2 pages):
  - Describe the learning culture you want to create in your classroom/group
  - Write an inclusive description/invitation to a mindfulness course you wish to offer
  - Identify 5 inclusion practices that you will use
- How will you continue your learning in this area?
- How will you hold yourself accountable?

00 Check-ins: Two or three sentences about the energy you are bringing to the group today, and one thing that stays with you from the Session 6 video.

05 Pause-Relax-Open meditation

10 Review the ***Agreements for Multicultural Interactions*** by going around the circle with each person reading one agreement.

15 **Sharing.** Go around the circle with each person sharing; please divide the time equally among participants, and wait until everyone has shared before sharing again.

- What is the kind of learning culture that you want to create in your classroom or group, as you look toward designing your practicum in year two of the MMTCP? What do you want it to feel like for you, for the students? What is your ideal for how you'd be engaging with one another?
- What is one example of a story, tradition, or artwork from your culture that you can bring in to illustrate a specific mindfulness teaching, like working with thoughts, compassion, etc.?

45 Checkout:

- What are you taking away from these sessions?
- What is (at least) one thing you are proud of about how you engaged with this material?
- What is (at least) one thing you appreciate about this group?